



sports. “Standing on a tennis court, I told him I wanted to play table tennis. And ever since, my life has revolved around the game,” Harmeet says.

Once he got hooked, Harmeet’s life revolved around a 9’x5” table, and the Desai household revolved around his table tennis. Realising that Harmeet was meant to be an odd-one out in Surat — where kids typically aspired to join the renowned diamond hub or become stockbrokers — his parents adapted their professions to support him.

After winding up their stockbroking firm, Rajul devoted himself to Harmeet’s table tennis, while Archana, who was Harmeet’s

first opponent at home, joined a school as a principal. Hraday, a fierce competitor on the table and still one of his tactical go-to persons, motivated him to dream bigger.

The family was keen on nurturing Harmeet’s passion for table tennis, which quickly developed into an obsession. But Surat, being a small town, lacked a sporting culture and the necessary expertise. As a result, Harmeet’s parents started inviting outstation coaches for sessions and sending him away on training stints since his early teen days.

Harmeet’s selection for and sustenance at the Petroleum Sports Promotion Board (PSPB) Academy in Ajmer for a year as an eight-year-old

On the rise: Over the last three years, Harmeet has emerged as India’s highest-ranked men’s singles paddler in the world. K. MURALI KUMAR

truly convinced his parents about his passion.

Since the early 1990s, the Academy has been the dream destination for aspiring paddlers in India, where Harmeet became the youngest ever to be selected. “I was just eight years old, and till date, nobody that young has enrolled in the Academy. I stayed there, and for my parents, it was a shock,” he recalls.

“When we went to Pune for the